



The glamour of air travel

By the late 1950s traveling by air was available to more people than ever before. No longer the preserve of the ultra-rich, flying nevertheless remained a fairly luxurious and glamorous affair, and ticket prices were relatively high. Air hostesses were considered a key part of the experience, and were hired as much for their appearance as for their skills in looking after passengers.

TWA (Trans World Airlines), founded in 1930, was one of the "Big Four" airlines in the US market, alongside American Airlines, United Airlines, and Eastern Airlines, and was the main competitor with Pan Am for international flights. Those hostesses lucky enough to work for TWA were expected to keep their weight at a certain level and wear regulation make-up.

Until 1957 TWA air hostesses were not allowed to remain with the company once they were married. Airline passengers, meanwhile, enjoyed a high level of service and comfort with complimentary food and drink.

The popularity of TWA with movie stars and executives added to its allure. Its unofficial name, "Airline to the Stars," resulted from images of stars such as Marilyn Monroe and Elizabeth Taylor boarding flights. Movie mogul and aviation fanatic Howard Hughes owned a controlling share of the company.

This image of an all-American family from a 1950s magazine advert for TWA conveys the excitement and style associated with flying in this era.